

The 3:10 Shift

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

I want you to look across this fire for a minute before I start. Not at me. At the man in the gray hoodie on the far side of the ring, the one who keeps feeding split oak into the coals with a folded newspaper under his boot so the bark doesn't roll. Watch how he covers a dry cough with the back of his wrist, and every time he does it the chair under him creaks, a metal folding chair with a cup holder punched into the arm, and that dented blue thermos standing in the holder has been there since we lit this thing.

My name is Deshawn. I was eleven in April of 2020, and I'm seventeen now, and this is a story about an old man named Walt Kostelnik who lived alone in a brick ranch off West Tilghman, out toward Cetronia, in a house that still smelled like his wife's hand lotion three weeks after she was gone. It's also a story about my father, and about a hospital on South Cedar Crest Boulevard where nobody's family was allowed upstairs, and about a little answering machine that sat on a hall table and kept a stack of microcassettes in a shoe box beside it. I won't preach. Here's what happened.

Walt was seventy-nine that April, retired from Mack Trucks after thirty-four years on the Macungie line, cab and chassis work at the plant on Alburtis Road, and his hands still carried the shape of the tools. June had been the believer. Walt had been the one who drove her to church on Sundays and sat in the truck with the radio low and a travel mug of coffee, waiting for the doors to open and the people to come out. Walt loved her and didn't share her certainty. On their fortieth anniversary she had given him a card with a truck on it and written inside, in the same block print she used on the tape labels, You do not have to sing. Just sit with me. The card stayed in his sock drawer under the good watches. When she got sick in the winter and went into the hospital at Cedar Crest, and when the visitor ban locked down on the fifteenth of March, he sat in that ranch with her Bible on the nightstand and her slippers under the bed and her voice saved on those little tapes, and he didn't know how to be a widower in a county that had been told to stay home.

Lehigh County's stay-at-home order had come down on the twenty-fifth of March at eight at night. By the first of April the whole state was under it. The grocery stores put arrows on the floors. The churches went to parking-lot services and then to screens. Walt's daughter Theresa was an ICU nurse at Cedar Crest, and she was the only person who came to the house, and even she came in the driveway and talked to him through the storm door with a mask on, because she wouldn't carry the ward into his kitchen. Once she left a paper bag of masks and a bottle of hand gel on the step with a note that said USE THESE, DAD in the handwriting she had learned from June. Walt put the gel under the sink and wore a mask to the Acme on Tilghman and hated the way his glasses fogged, and he went early so the aisles would be empty.

The ranch was a quiet place in those weeks. Mail came late. The neighbor's dog barked at delivery trucks and then gave up. Walt kept the television on low for company and turned it off

when the numbers started crawling across the bottom of the news, because the numbers didn't help him wash a dish or make a bed. Walt swept the walk even when nobody walked it, and he checked the oil in the Buick even though he barely drove. During the third day of the statewide order Walt stood in June's closet for a long time with his hand on the sleeve of her church coat, the blue one with the good buttons, and then shut the door and left the coat where it was. On trash morning he wore his work jacket from the plant to the curb, the one with his name still stitched over the pocket in red thread June had sealed with clear nail polish so it wouldn't fray.

In the second week of April, on a Tuesday, the answering machine's light was blinking when Walt came in from the curb. One message. Walt set the bag down and pressed play with his thumb. The cassette hissed for half a second, the soft grit of tape against the heads, and then June's voice filled the hall the way it used to when she left him a note about the grocery list.

"Walt, I put the good scissors back in the junk drawer. Stop looking in the sewing box. I love you."

The counter on the face of the machine showed 012. Walt knew that tape. June had left that message three years before, on a Thursday when he had been under the sink with a wrench and couldn't hear the phone, and he had saved it because he liked the sound of her being practical at him. Why the machine had played it now he couldn't say. Nobody had dialed in. With his hand on the plastic lid he listened to the quiet after her voice cut off, and then he pressed stop, and then he pressed rewind and held it until the counter rolled back to 000, and then he took his hand away.

That was the first one.

Walt made himself walk into the kitchen and open the junk drawer. The good scissors were there, under a roll of masking tape and a half-used book of stamps. Walt shut the drawer

with his hip. Outside, a wind moved the empty bird feeder June had kept filled through every winter, and the feeder bumped the porch post in a slow irregular knock he had meant to fix since February. Walt stood at the sink with a glass of water and listened to that knock for a full minute before he turned away.

Theresa called him that same evening from the staff lot, sitting in her car with the engine off and the windows cracked. Her cheekbones had red marks from the mask straps. Walt could hear a helicopter somewhere over the valley, and under it the thin sound of her breathing through the phone.

"Dad," she said. "You eating?"

"I heated the stew," he said. "The one in the blue lid."

"Good. Listen. I have a patient. Marcus. Forty-one. On a vent. His boy is eleven. The boy's name is Deshawn. The grandmother brings him to the lot and they sit in a gray Honda and wait for me to call them on the iPad so they can see his face. I'm telling you because I can't tell him what I want to tell him, and I have to tell somebody."

Walt sat down at the kitchen table. June's placemat was still under his elbow, the woven one with the faded strawberries.

"Is he going to make it?" Walt asked.

"I don't know," Theresa said. "I'm doing the work. That's what I know."

After she hung up, Walt washed the stew bowl and set it in the rack. The clock over the stove read 8:40. Back in the hall the answering machine light was dark, and Walt left the buttons alone. That night he slept in an old nightshirt of his that June used to steal for painting, and he left the hall light on the way he always had when she was alive so she could find the bathroom without waking him.

Wednesday morning Walt made coffee in the old percolator because the drip machine had a cracked carafe and he had never replaced it. While it gurgled he opened June's Bible on the counter. Soft pencil filled the margins. In Luke, beside a verse she had marked 22:32 without writing the words out, she had printed in her small block letters: 3:10, for Walt. Walt ran his thumb over the graphite. The page had a thin oil stain at the bottom corner from her hand cream. Closing the book, he set his palm on the cover and stood there until the percolator hissed and spit, and then poured the coffee and drank it black at the sink, looking out at the empty street.

Three-ten sat in his head. June had always disappeared into the back bedroom around that time with the door half shut. Reading, he had figured, though the question never left his mouth. A man can live beside a woman for forty-six years and still leave a whole room of her life unentered if she doesn't invite him in and he doesn't knock.

At noon the machine blinked again, and Walt pressed play. Hiss, then June from a different tape, the counter jumping to 047, a message he remembered from a church picnic she had wanted him to attend.

"You don't have to believe every word they say in there," she said on the tape. "You only have to keep showing up for the people. That's half of it, Walt. Showing up."

Walt let the message run out, rewound it to 000 with his finger on the button until the motor clicked off, and put the lid down. In the kitchen Walt washed the mug and left it mouth-down on a towel.

I need you to understand how ordinary that house was. The fridge had a magnet from the Macungie plant Christmas party, a little chrome bulldog. The hall carpet had a worn track from the front door to the bathroom. On the mantel there was a framed picture of Theresa in her nursing school whites, and beside it a wooden model of a Mack cab Walt had built on weekends

out of balsa and glue, the mirrors no bigger than apple seeds. A housefly kept landing on the lip of the kitchen faucet that week, and Walt kept shooing it with a dish towel.

Thursday Theresa texted him a grocery list and asked him to leave the bags in the trunk of her car in the hospital lot at three, because she would be coming off a stretch and she didn't want him near the doors. Walt wrote the list on the back of an envelope in the block print he used for work orders: milk and bread and sharp cheddar, and apples if they looked decent. Walt drove the old Buick down Cedar Crest with the windows up and the radio off. The lot at Cedar Crest was half full of cars that didn't look like staff cars. People sat in them with the engines off, waiting on phone calls. A woman in a minivan had a rosary hanging from the mirror. A man in a pickup had his forehead on the steering wheel. Walt found Theresa's blue Corolla under a light pole and put the bags in the trunk the way she had asked, and then he stood there with his keys in his hand and didn't get back in the Buick right away.

A gray Honda was parked two rows over. A boy about eleven sat in the passenger seat with a homework folder on his knees. An older woman sat behind the wheel with a phone pressed to her ear. I was that boy, and I didn't know Walt's name yet. All I knew was that a tall old man in a brown jacket was standing by a Corolla with grocery bags, and that he lifted his hand once, not quite a wave, when he caught me looking.

Walt went home. At 3:05 by the stove clock he sat down at the kitchen table with June's Bible closed under his hand. At 3:10 he didn't pray. Walt sat while the refrigerator hummed and a truck went by on Tilghman and a floorboard in the house ticked as it cooled, and he stayed that way until 3:20, after which Walt rose and washed a spoon he had already washed, because his hands needed a job.

Friday the machine blinked while he was out sweeping the walk. Walt came in, saw the light, and pressed play with the broom still in his other hand. Hiss. Counter 091. June's voice, softer, from a night she had called him from her sister's in Bethlehem.

"I know you're angry at God about your back," she said. "Be angry. Just don't stop listening. He can take a man's temper. I have seen it."

Walt had hurt his back in '98 on a lift assist at the plant, and he had forgotten she had left that message. Setting the broom against the wall, he rewound the tape to 000, then stood in the hall with both hands on the edge of the table until his shoulders dropped, and then he went and made a grilled cheese and ate it over the sink so the crumbs wouldn't get on June's placemat.

That evening Theresa called from inside the hospital. Walt could hear the ward behind her, the steady machine sounds, a cart wheel squeaking.

"Marcus had a rough afternoon," she said. "Deshawn asked me if his dad could hear him through the tube. I told him yes. I don't know if that's true. I told him yes anyway."

"You did right," Walt said.

"Dad. Do you ever..." She stopped. He heard her swallow. "Never mind. I have to go. The iPad is ringing."

After the call Walt walked to the hall again. The light on the machine was dark. Walt opened the shoe box of microcassettes. Each one had June's handwriting on the tiny label: picnic, scissors, Bethlehem, Theresa grad, Christmas 12. One cassette at the bottom had no label, and he left it where it was and closed the box. In the bathroom Walt washed his face with the bar soap June had always bought, the plain white kind, and dried his face on a towel that still had her lipstick smear near the tag from a morning she had been in a hurry.

I should tell you what those days were like for me, because I was in that Honda more hours than I was in any classroom that spring. School had gone to a screen on the kitchen table at my grandmother's row house off Fourth, and the screen froze, and the teachers looked tired, and none of it mattered beside the fact that my father was on a machine that breathed for him. My grandmother packed sandwiches in wax paper and a jug of water and a charger for the phone, and we drove to Cedar Crest and parked where Theresa told us to park, and we waited. When the iPad call came through, I saw my father's face the way you see a person under water, distant and wrong, with tape and tubes, and I told him about the shark book and about the neighbor's cat that had kittens, and my grandmother told him she had paid the electric, and then the call ended and we sat with the quiet.

My grandmother's name is Ruth, and she kept a spare pair of reading glasses in the glove box and a packet of peanut butter crackers in the door pocket for when the waiting ran long. Games on the phone weren't allowed while we sat there. My father might wake up in some way we couldn't see and need to hear a real voice, she said, so I read the shark book out loud to the dashboard, chapter by chapter, until my throat got dry and she passed me the water jug. When I dropped cracker crumbs down the seat, she fished them out with two fingers and ate them herself, because waste was a sin in her house.

Walt didn't know any of that yet. Theresa had given him a name and a boy and a gray Honda, and that was the whole of it.

Saturday morning he drove back to the Cedar Crest lot with a thermos of coffee and two paper cups, and he set them on Theresa's roof under the wiper so she would see them when she came out. The gray Honda was there again. I was in the back seat this time with the library book about sharks. My grandmother was asleep with her mouth open and her rosary around her wrist.

Walt didn't come over. In the Buick with the door cracked he watched the hospital windows for a while, the ones that didn't tell you anything from the outside, and at ten minutes after three by the dashboard clock he got out and stood between the Buick and a painted line on the asphalt and took his cap off.

I saw him do it, and I didn't know what I was looking at then. Maybe he was tired. Old men take their caps off for all kinds of reasons.

Walt stood in that parking lot with his cap in both hands and his chin down, and for the first time in his life he prayed out loud. His voice was rough and low, and what he said wasn't fancy.

"I don't know how this works," he said. "June said you listen. If you're listening, this isn't for me. This is for a man named Marcus on a ventilator upstairs. His boy is in that Honda. Let him live. Let the boy keep his father. I don't have the words past that."

Cap back on, Walt got in the Buick and drove home on Cedar Crest with his hands at ten and two like he was still on his road test. A dump truck ahead of him tapped its brakes at the light by Tilghman, and Walt tapped his, and the thermos rolled once on the passenger floor mat and stopped against his work boot.

Upstairs, at the same clock time, Theresa was at Marcus's bed with her gloved hand on the rail. Theresa didn't know her father was in the lot. Thirty seconds between tasks was all she had, and she used them the way June had taught her when she was small, head down, mouth moving behind the mask.

"Lord, hold Marcus," she said. "Hold Deshawn. Hold my dad sitting in that house. Amen."

Theresa went back to the lines and the numbers and the work. I'm telling you they happened at the same time because Theresa checked the charge nurse's clock when she finished, and Walt checked the dashboard when he turned the key, and both clocks said 3:10, and that's as far as the fact goes.

On the drive home the light at Cedar Crest and Hamilton held him longer than it should have. A man in scrubs crossed in front of the Buick with his head down and a lunch bag swinging, and Walt waited, both hands on the wheel, until the man cleared the crosswalk. A paper mask lay flat in the gutter by the bus shelter, blue side up, and Walt watched the wind lift it and set it down twice before the light changed. June's pencil note sat in his head beside the boy with the shark book, and he kept himself out of the petition if he could help it.

Walt got home and the answering machine light was blinking.

Walt set his keys in the dish and lifted the lid before he touched a button. The cassette sitting in the well had no label. He opened the shoe box beside the machine and looked at the bottom, where the blank one had been lying since Friday, and the bottom was bare cardboard. He closed the box. Then he pressed play, and the counter ran to 003 with a longer hiss this time, a thin room sound under it, and then June's voice came through clear, closer to the microphone than on the older tapes, as if she had the phone right against her mouth.

"Theresa's here," June said. "She can't hear me talk past the machine. That's all right. Walt. Listen to me. If it comes down to it, let him pray for somebody else first. Do you hear me. Somebody else first. Then the rest will follow. I love you. I'm not afraid."

The tape clicked and left the counter at 028, and the machine's little voice read off the stamp: Wednesday, 3:10 a.m.

Walt stood in the hall and pressed stop without rewinding yet, then walked to the kitchen and called Theresa, and she answered on the second try from a supply closet where she went when the ward got too loud inside her head.

"Dad."

"The night your mother died," Walt said. "You were in the room."

"Yes."

"What did you hear."

Theresa was quiet long enough that he heard a pager go off somewhere behind her.

"The ventilator," she said. "That's what I heard. The ventilator, and the alarms we silenced, and a chaplain at the door who couldn't come in past the line. She didn't talk, Dad. Not that I could hear. I held her hand through a glove and I watched the numbers and I told her about you sitting at home because they wouldn't let you up. That's what I heard."

"All right," Walt said.

"Why."

"I'll tell you later," he said. "Go back to work."

Walt hung up and walked back to the hall. On the tape, June's voice was clear: let him pray for somebody else first. In the room at Cedar Crest that night, Theresa heard only the ventilator. Those are the two facts I have for you. I'm not going to put a bridge between them. Walt put his finger on the rewind button and held it until the counter went to 000, and then he took the cassette out, wrote JUNE FINAL in pencil on the little label strip, and set it back in the shoe box on top of the others.

In the kitchen he made a sandwich he didn't eat and wrapped it in wax paper and put it in the fridge beside a jar of pickles that had been there since before June went into the hospital.

Walt washed the butter knife, dried it, and set it in the drawer in its right place, blade turned in, the way she had always insisted so nobody would grab the edge in the dark.

That night he slept in the chair in the living room with June's Bible on his knee, open to the Luke page with her pencil mark. At three in the morning Walt woke up and the house was quiet in the way houses are quiet when the traffic on Tilghman has thinned out. Walt closed the Bible and went to bed. In the dark the tape motor still ran in his head, that small plastic whir, until sleep took the rest.

Sunday he stayed away from the lot and made oatmeal. Then he called Theresa and asked after Marcus, and she said the numbers were a little better, which in ICU talk means a person might be turning or might not, and you don't build a house on it. Walt washed the oatmeal pot. At 3:10 he sat at the kitchen table again, and this time he prayed, out loud, for Marcus, and for Theresa's hands, and for a boy in a Honda with a shark book, and he kept his eyes open because closing them still struck him as foolish. When he finished he got up and dried the pot and hung the towel on the oven door.

Sunday night he took the kitchen calendar off its nail, the free one from the funeral home on Tilghman with a covered bridge for April, and he wrote 3:10 in the square for every day left in the month. Walt used the carpenter's pencil from the junk drawer, the flat one he had to sharpen with a pocketknife, and his block letters came out heavy enough to dent the next page. When he hung the calendar back on its nail it sat crooked. He left it crooked. June would have straightened it on her way past, and every morning the crooked page told him that nobody had walked past.

The machine stayed dark Monday and Tuesday. Walt found himself walking into the hall to check the light anyway, the way you check a stove burner you already turned off. On

Wednesday Theresa called from the car with her mask hanging off one ear and her voice cracked from twelve hours inside.

"They are going to try to wean Marcus tomorrow," she said. "If it goes well, Deshawn might hear his dad's voice by the weekend. Dad. What did you do."

"I bought cheddar," Walt said.

"That isn't what I asked."

Walt looked at the machine. The light was dark. His hand rested on the plastic lid, and then he took his hand away.

"I asked for help for your patient," he said. "In the lot. That's all."

Theresa made a sound that was half a laugh and half the other thing people do when they have been holding a ward up with their shoulders, and then she said she had to go pick up her own groceries out of the trunk before the milk turned, and she hung up.

I met Walt properly the Saturday after that. Marcus had the tube out. His voice was a ruin, but it was his voice. My grandmother cried in the Honda with her forehead on the steering wheel. Theresa walked out in her scrubs and stood six feet from our bumper and told us we could wave at a window on the third floor if we wanted, and we did, like fools, waving at reflective glass. Walt was in the lot again with his thermos. Theresa brought him over, still at a distance, and said, "Deshawn, this is my dad. He's been praying for your dad."

Walt looked at me like I was a job he intended to finish.

"You like sharks," Walt said, because the library book had been visible through the glass the week before.

"Yes, sir."

"Great whites are bullies," he said. "I always liked the hammerheads. They mind their business."

That's the first thing Walt Kostelnik ever said to me. I still don't know if he believed what he was doing when he stood in that lot with his cap in his hands. I know he kept doing it. Three-ten became a shift he clocked into the way he used to clock into Macungie, whether he was in the kitchen or in the Buick or, later, on a folding chair in my grandmother's yard once the bans eased and people could stand outside again with a little air between them.

Marcus came home in May with a walker and a list of exercises and a temper short as a match, because living costs you, and getting well is work. Walt brought over a casserole June's sister had taught him and set it on our porch and rang the bell and went back to his car before we opened the door, because old habits from the ban months die slow. My father ate two plates standing up at the counter and said the man could cook for a living if the trucks ever ran out.

Walt brought a second folding chair over one Thursday in June, the metal kind with the woven straps, and he sat with my father while my father practiced walking to the maple tree and back. The yard on Fourth Street was small and the fence leaned, and Ruth had planted tomatoes in buckets along the sunny side. Walt knew tomato suckers from his own yard with June. Walt pinched one off without being asked and dropped it in the grass, and Ruth watched from the kitchen window and didn't come out to stop him. Marcus hated the walker. Walt didn't offer advice. Walt drank coffee from the dented blue thermos and watched a robin yell at a squirrel in the grass, and when Marcus finished the lap Walt said, "Again," the way a foreman says it when the weld is good and the day isn't over.

June's slippers stayed under the bed until Theresa finally boxed them that same spring. The model Mack cab stayed on the mantel. The answering machine stayed on the hall table

through the summer, and Walt left the JUNE FINAL tape in the shoe box, and he didn't play it again in front of anyone. When I asked him about it a year later, sitting on his back step with two glasses of lemonade, he told me what was on it, word for word, and he told me what Theresa heard in the room, and then he drank his lemonade and watched a neighbor kid ride a bike with a playing card in the spokes, and he didn't add a theory.

"I took the shift," he said. "That's the part that belongs to me."

There was a stretch in July when my father's cough got wet again and we all went quiet for a week, and Walt called Theresa twice a day, and Theresa called the pulmonologist, and the pulmonologist said rest and fluids and watch the fever. Walt prayed at three-ten on the back step with a mosquito on his forearm he didn't bother to slap. My father got through it. The maple tree kept making shade. I went back to a classroom in the fall with a mask and a desk that had been wiped so many times the wood was pale.

Years went by the way years do, and I grew, and Walt got slower, and Theresa moved to a day shift and married a respiratory therapist who understood why she still woke at two in the morning listening for alarms that weren't there. The ranch got a new drip coffee machine. The shoe box of tapes stayed in the hall closet after Walt finally took the machine off the table, and once, when I helped him clean, I held the one marked JUNE FINAL in my palm and noticed how light a whole goodbye can sit, lighter than a pack of gum. I didn't play it. It wasn't mine to play.

Walt taught me to change the oil in the Buick the summer I turned fifteen. Walt made me put the drain plug in a coffee can so I wouldn't lose it in the gravel, and he made me wipe the filter seal before I spun the new one on, and when I asked him why he still prayed at three-ten even though my dad had been fine for years, Walt wiped his hands on a rag and said, "Shift is a shift. Somebody is always on a hard clock somewhere."

The last autumn Walt was alive he asked me to help him put the storm windows on the ranch. We worked until our fingers went stiff, and he paid me in apple pie from the frozen section and a story about a night shift at Macungie when a whole line stopped because one bolt had been left in a pocket instead of a flange. Walt told stories like that when he didn't want to talk about the other things. I ate the pie with a fork out of the tin and listened.

Which brings me back to this fire.

I told you to watch the man in the gray hoodie, the one feeding the oak, dry cough and all, metal chair with the cup holder, dented blue thermos that has been standing there since we lit the wood.

That man is my dad. Marcus lived.

Walt took the three-ten shift so a boy in a Honda could keep hearing a voice on the other end of a phone, and then so that same boy could sit across a fire from the man who almost didn't make it out of Cedar Crest. Walt isn't at this fire tonight. Last winter he died in his own bed with Theresa holding his hand and no ventilator in the room at all. Theresa let me help box the kitchen. I wrapped the strawberry placemat in newspaper and put it in with the plates. On his nightstand, when we cleaned out the ranch, we found June's Bible open to that Luke page, and in Walt's thicker pencil under her old note he had added one line.

"3:10. For whoever needs it."

I still pray at three-ten when I remember. Some days I forget. On the days I remember, I don't pray for myself first. I learned that from an old Mack hand who kept showing up.

The oak pops. Sparks go up. Across the ring my father feeds another piece into the coals and covers his cough with his wrist, and the thermos in the cup holder ticks as it cools, and that's the end of what I came to tell you.

END